

פרשת תולדות. One of the most famous lines in all of our Torah literature comes from the ברכות of יצחק to יעקב אבינו, which he was able to snatch away from עשו with his mother's help. Right before he gives him the bracha, יצחק says: (27:22) וַיִּגַּשׁ יַעֲקֹב אֶל יִצְחָק אָבִיו וַיִּמָּשְׁהוּ וַיֹּאמֶר הִקֵּל קוֹל יַעֲקֹב וְהַיָּדִים יְדֵי עֵשָׂו. Rashi explains that יצחק meant that יעקב was speaking nicely to him, something that עשו did not usually do. However, יעקב's hands were hairy because of the ridiculous outfit he was wearing.

A מדרש on the phrase קוֹל יַעֲקֹב הִקֵּל goes as follows: מדרשות אין ידי - When we hear the קוֹל of יעקב, then the hands of עשו will not have any power over us. All the מפרשים ask why the מדרש is telling us that? It says קוֹל יַעֲקֹב וְהַיָּדִים יְדֵי עֵשָׂו, not קוֹל יַעֲקֹב, not יְדֵי עֵשָׂו. Even if it's a קוֹל יַעֲקֹב, it's still the יְדֵי עֵשָׂו, the pasuk does not sound like it's one or the other, it sounds like both can be true at the same time. How do we understand what the מדרש is trying to tell us?

The מדרש in his inimitable style points out an interesting fact. The מדרש says, ברכות, קוֹל יַעֲקֹב נשמע בבתי, מלא. When the קוֹל יַעֲקֹב, then אין הידים ידי עשו. מלא. When the קוֹל יַעֲקֹב, then אין הידים ידי עשו.

If you look in the pasuk carefully, which of course is what we should always do, it says קוֹל יַעֲקֹב הִקֵּל. The first קל is a חסר, it's missing a ו'. That is critical. קל without a ו' is קל. Meaning, when we slack off in our work and efforts, the קוֹל יַעֲקֹב is getting weaker, it's a חסר, then ידי עשו. However, if we put in our full כוחות in השם without any kind of slackening, בהם, אין ידי עשו שולטות בהם, which is what the מדרש says.

This is a tremendous מוסר השכל. We constantly have to think that there's no time for vacation, there's no time for letting up. We have to keep up our efforts at all times. In that זכות, we will be זוכה to have the fulfilled and הארץ. We'll get עולם הזה and עולם הבא as רבקה wanted for us.

